

THREAT INTELLIGENCE SERIES

D1907-2026-003

DATASTREAM COWBOY

SUMMARY

PAGE 1 / 7

DOSSIER 1907

THREAT INTELLIGENCE SERIES

TABLE OF CONTENTS

01 Executive Summary	3
02 Key Findings	4
03 Technical Analysis	5
04 Assessment	6
05 References	7

01 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

In the spring of 1994, a British teenager operating under the handle "Datastream Cowboy" broke into Rome Laboratory, a U.S. Air Force research facility in New York working on artificial intelligence and radar guidance systems. Over 26 days, he and an older accomplice known only as "Kuji" penetrated the lab's network more than 150 times.

Datastream Cowboy was 16 years old, working from his bedroom, with no formal hacking background beyond curiosity and a modem.

WARNING

At one point, investigators traced an intrusion the pair launched from Rome Lab's compromised systems toward a nuclear research facility. If it had turned out to be in North Korea rather than South Korea, U.S. officials feared it could have looked, from Pyongyang's side, like an American military attack.

02 KEY FINDINGS

- Over 150 confirmed intrusions into Rome Laboratory in 26 days.
- Access obtained through a default guest password, escalated using a password-sniffing tool.
- Attacks routed through international phone switches across multiple continents to resist tracing.
- Compromised systems were used as a pivot point to reach NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratory, Goddard Space Flight Center, and a South Korean nuclear research institute.
- The younger hacker was identified as a minor and fined; his older collaborator was acquitted, as no applicable law existed in his home country at the time.

03 TECHNICAL ANALYSIS

Datastream Cowboy's initial access exploited nothing sophisticated – a default guest account left active on a Rome Laboratory system gave him a low-level foothold. From there, he installed a password-sniffing tool nicknamed "Carmen," designed to silently capture every credential used on the network as staff logged in, expanding his access from a single guest account to more than 100 compromised user accounts.

To resist tracing, he routed his connections through a chain of international telephone switches, phreaking his way through South America, Europe, and Mexico via unauthorized long-distance access before ever reaching the Rome Lab modem bank in New York. Investigators found he frequently retreated after a failed attempt on a target, exchanged email with Kuji for guidance, then returned and succeeded – a pattern that convinced U.S. Air Force investigators they were dealing with a coordinated team, though later independent review concluded the two had likely never met or even spoken by phone.

Once inside Rome Lab, the access became a springboard rather than an endpoint. The compromised network was used to reach outward into other high-value systems, including NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratory, Goddard Space Flight Center, and defense contractor Lockheed Martin. Air tasking order research, the kind of data used to plan real air combat operations, was among the material accessed.

The most serious moment came when investigators traced an attempted intrusion, launched using an assumed identity routed through the compromised Air Force systems, toward a nuclear research facility in Korea. For a tense stretch, officials could not confirm whether the target was in the North or the South. Had it been the North, the concern was that the intrusion would have appeared to originate from a U.S. military installation, rather than a British teenager's bedroom.

04 ASSESSMENT

DOSSIER 1907 assesses this case as one of the earliest clear demonstrations that a single unaffiliated individual, with minimal resources and no state backing, could generate intrusion-based effects with the potential for real geopolitical consequence entirely by accident. Datastream Cowboy had no strategic objective beyond curiosity; a later independent review found he had "no master plan."

The case pushed U.S. military and intelligence agencies to treat network intrusion detection as a genuine national security discipline rather than a purely technical IT problem, feeding directly into the buildup of dedicated information warfare units in the years that followed. Three decades later, the core lesson still holds: attribution during an active intrusion is difficult, and the gap between "who is actually attacking us" and "who does it look like is attacking us" can matter as much as the intrusion itself.

05 REFERENCES

1. United States General Accounting Office. Testimony before the Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations, Committee on Governmental Affairs, GAO/T-AIMD, 1996.
2. Black Hat Ethical Hacking. When two young hackers played war games with Pentagon.
3. ISC2. #CISSP30: 30 Years After Two Kids Broke into the Air Force, September 2024.
4. The IT Law Wiki. Air Force Rome Lab.